



A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR EVERYDAY BEGINNERS

The Beginner's Fitness Blueprint

Strength training, running and simple nutrition,
combined into one sustainable, science-based routine.

STRENGTH TRAINING

RUNNING

NUTRITION

HEALTHY HABITS

Backed by ACSM, WHO & ISSN guidelines • Beginner-friendly • No bro-science



SECTION 01

Introduction

Why this guide exists

Fitness is not a 90-day transformation. It is not a sprint toward a magazine-cover physique, and it definitely isn't something you either “nail” or “fail”. It's a long-term relationship with your own body — one built slowly, through small, repeatable actions.

This guide will not promise you a six-pack in three weeks or a marathon finish in a month. Instead, it gives you a realistic, evidence-based starting point that combines three pillars that work best together: **strength training**, **running**, and **simple, sustainable nutrition**.

**You don't need to become a bodybuilder.**

A few consistent sessions per week are enough to see real, lasting change.

**Small improvements compound.**

A 1% improvement each week adds up to a completely different body and mindset after a year.

**Health is the real goal.**

Feeling stronger, sleeping better and having more energy matter more than any number on a scale.

**How to use this book**

Read it once from start to finish, then come back to the training plan, running progression and nutrition calculator whenever you need them. This is a reference you'll return to — not a novel you read once and forget.



SECTION 02

Why Strength Training?

The foundation of a resilient body

Strength training is one of the most well-supported habits for long-term health. According to the World Health Organization and the American College of Sports Medicine (ACSM), adults should perform muscle-strengthening activities at least twice a week. Here's why it deserves a permanent place in your routine.

**Builds muscle and increases strength**

More muscle means more capability in everyday movements — carrying groceries, climbing stairs, playing with your kids.

**Improves posture**

A stronger back, core and shoulders counteract the effects of long hours sitting at a desk.

**Boosts metabolism**

Muscle tissue burns more energy at rest than fat tissue, supporting long-term weight management.

**Protects your joints**

Stronger muscles and connective tissue reduce the risk of injury during daily life and sport.

**Improves quality of life**

Research consistently links resistance training with better bone density, balance and independence as we age.



Evidence-based takeaway: The ACSM recommends training each major muscle group 2–3 times per week, with at least 48 hours of rest between sessions targeting the same muscles.



SECTION 03

Why Running?

Simple, accessible cardio that works

Running is one of the most accessible forms of cardiovascular exercise — all you need is a pair of shoes and a bit of pavement or trail. It complements strength training by developing a completely different set of adaptations.

**Improves cardiovascular health**

Regular aerobic activity strengthens the heart and improves circulation, in line with WHO physical activity guidelines.

**Burns calories efficiently**

Running is one of the most time-efficient ways to create an energy deficit when combined with good nutrition.

**Increases endurance**

Your aerobic base improves steadily, making daily activities and other sports feel easier.

**Reduces stress**

Aerobic exercise is associated with lower cortisol levels and improved mood.

**Improves sleep**

Regular moderate cardio is linked with falling asleep faster and experiencing deeper sleep.

**Why combine strength training and running?**

Strength training builds the muscle and joint resilience that protects you while running, while running builds the aerobic engine that helps you recover faster between strength sessions. Together, they cover both sides of fitness: power and endurance.



SECTION 04

Weekly Training Plan

A beginner-friendly weekly template

This is a starting template, not a rulebook. Adapt the days to fit your schedule — what matters is the overall balance between strength work, easy running and recovery.

Day	Focus
Monday	Rest
Tuesday	Upper Body Strength + Easy Run (20 min)
Wednesday	Lower Body Strength
Thursday	Easy Run (25–30 min)
Friday	Full Body Strength
Saturday	Long Easy Run
Sunday	Active Recovery (walk, stretch, mobility)



3 strength sessions per week

Covers upper body, lower body and a full-body session — enough stimulus for beginners to build strength without burning out.



3 running sessions per week

A mix of easy efforts and one longer run builds your aerobic base gradually and safely.



1 full rest day + 1 active recovery day

Recovery is where your body actually adapts and gets stronger — don't skip it.



This is only a template

Swap days around freely to fit work, family or social commitments. The key principle is spacing: try not to stack two hard sessions back-to-back without any easier day between them.



SECTION 05

Strength Training Basics

The vocabulary you need to get started



Reps (repetitions)
One complete movement of an exercise, e.g. one full squat from standing to depth and back up.



Sets
A group of consecutive reps performed without stopping, followed by a rest period.



Progressive overload
Gradually increasing weight, reps or sets over time so your muscles keep adapting.



Rest periods
60–90 seconds between sets is typically enough for beginners to recover and maintain good technique.



Technique before load
Master the movement pattern with lighter weight first; add load only once form is consistent.

A Simple Beginner Full-Body Workout

Perform this 2–3 times per week, resting a day between sessions. Aim for 3 sets of 8–12 reps per exercise once you're comfortable with the movement.

Exercise	Sets × Reps	Targets
Goblet Squat	3 × 8–12	Legs, glutes, core
Push-Up (or knee push-up)	3 × 6–12	Chest, shoulders, triceps
Dumbbell Row	3 × 8–12	Back, biceps
Glute Bridge	3 × 10–15	Glutes, hamstrings, core
Plank	3 × 20–40 sec	Core stability



Progression tip
Once you can comfortably complete all sets and reps with good form, increase the weight slightly (2–5%) or add one extra rep per set next session. That's progressive overload in action.



SECTION 06

Running Plan

An 8-week beginner progression

This progression gradually builds your running endurance using a run/walk method, which reduces injury risk and keeps the process enjoyable. Always run at a **conversational pace** — if you can't hold a conversation, slow down.

Week	Session
Week 1	20-minute brisk walk, 3–4 times this week
Week 2	Alternate 1 min jog / 2 min walk, for 20 minutes
Week 3	Alternate 3 min jog / 2 min walk, for 24 minutes
Week 4	20-minute continuous easy run
Week 5	25-minute continuous easy run
Week 6	30-minute continuous easy run
Week 7	35-minute continuous easy run
Week 8	40-minute continuous easy run



Conversational pace

You should always be able to speak in short sentences while running. If you can't, slow down.



Recovery between runs

Leave at least one day between running sessions during the first few weeks to let your joints and connective tissue adapt.



Listen to your body

Mild muscle fatigue is normal; sharp or joint pain is not. Repeat a week if needed — there's no prize for rushing.



SECTION 07

Nutrition Made Simple

The five things that actually matter

Nutrition doesn't need to be complicated. Once you understand these five concepts, you have everything you need to eat in a way that supports your training and your goals.

**Calories**

The energy your body needs. Eating consistently above or below your needs drives weight gain or loss over time.

**Protein**

Builds and repairs muscle tissue. Especially important if you're strength training regularly.

**Carbohydrates**

Your body's preferred fuel for training — particularly useful around running and strength sessions.

**Fats**

Essential for hormone production and long-term health; don't fear them, just don't overdo them.

**Hydration**

Even mild dehydration can hurt performance and recovery. Water is the simplest performance supplement you have.

**Keep it practical**

You don't need to weigh every gram of food forever. Start by building meals around a protein source, a carbohydrate source, some fat, and vegetables — then adjust based on how you feel and progress.



SECTION 08

Calculate Your Daily Nutrition

A simple, evidence-based estimate

You can estimate your daily calorie needs in three steps: calculate your Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR), multiply it by an activity factor to get your Total Daily Energy Expenditure (TDEE), then adjust slightly for your goal.

Step 1 — Estimate your BMR (Mifflin-St Jeor equation)

Formula	
Men	$10 \times \text{weight(kg)} + 6.25 \times \text{height(cm)} - 5 \times \text{age} + 5$
Women	$10 \times \text{weight(kg)} + 6.25 \times \text{height(cm)} - 5 \times \text{age} - 161$

Step 2 — Multiply by your activity level

Activity level	Multiplier
Sedentary (little/no exercise)	$\times 1.2$
Lightly active (1–3 sessions/week)	$\times 1.375$
Moderately active (3–5 sessions/week)	$\times 1.55$
Very active (6–7 sessions/week)	$\times 1.725$

Step 3 — Adjust for your goal, then split macros



Fat loss

A modest 15–20% calorie deficit below TDEE supports steady, sustainable fat loss.



Maintenance

Eat at roughly your TDEE to maintain your current weight while building fitness.



Muscle gain

A small surplus of around 200–300 calories above TDEE supports muscle growth without excess fat gain.



Macronutrient guidelines (ISSN)

Protein: approximately 1.6–2.2 g per kg of body weight for people strength training regularly. **Fat:** around 20–35% of total calories. **Carbohydrates:** fill the remaining calories after protein and fat are set.



SECTION 08

Worked Examples

Three realistic profiles

**Maria — 32, 165 cm, 68 kg, sedentary job, goal: fat loss**

BMR $\approx 1,390$ kcal $\rightarrow$ TDEE $\approx 1,670$ kcal ($\times 1.2$). With a 20% deficit: $\approx 1,340$ kcal/day — Protein 122 g, Fat 37 g, Carbs ≈ 129 g.

**James — 45, 178 cm, 82 kg, moderately active, goal: maintenance**

BMR $\approx 1,713$ kcal $\rightarrow$ TDEE $\approx 2,650$ kcal ($\times 1.55$). Eating at maintenance: $\approx 2,650$ kcal/day — Protein 148 g, Fat 88 g, Carbs ≈ 316 g.

**Sofia — 24, 160 cm, 55 kg, very active, goal: muscle gain**

BMR $\approx 1,269$ kcal $\rightarrow$ TDEE $\approx 2,190$ kcal ($\times 1.725$). With a +300 kcal surplus: $\approx 2,490$ kcal/day — Protein 110 g, Fat 69 g, Carbs ≈ 357 g.

These figures are general educational estimates based on population formulas, not individualized medical or dietetic advice. Individual needs vary — consult a registered dietitian or physician for a personalized plan.



SECTION 09

Recovery

Where the real progress happens

Training creates the stimulus for change — but your body actually adapts and gets stronger during recovery. Skipping recovery is one of the most common beginner mistakes.

**Sleep**

Aim for 7–9 hours per night. Sleep is when the majority of muscle repair and hormone regulation takes place.

**Stress management**

Chronic high stress raises cortisol and can blunt recovery and progress — build in downtime, not just workouts.

**Hydration**

Proper hydration supports every recovery process in the body, from digestion to muscle repair.

**Active recovery**

Light walks, stretching or mobility work on rest days keep blood flowing without adding fatigue.

**Recovery is not optional**

If you're constantly sore, tired or losing motivation, that's a sign to prioritize sleep and rest — not to push harder. Progress happens in the balance between stress and recovery.



SECTION 10

Mindset

The habits that actually last

**Consistency beats motivation**

Motivation fades. A simple system you can follow on your worst days is what carries you through the year.

**Don't compare yourself to social media**

Most transformation photos hide months of specific lighting, angles and effort you don't see. Compare yourself only to your own past self.

**Progress takes time**

Meaningful, lasting change in strength and body composition typically takes months, not days or weeks.

**One missed workout won't ruin your progress**

What matters is the pattern over months, not any single session. Miss one, then simply return to the plan.

**Habits beat perfection**

A sustainable 80%-effort routine you can maintain for years beats a perfect routine you quit after three weeks.

**A simple rule to remember**

If you can't do the perfect version of your workout, do a smaller version instead. Ten minutes of movement is infinitely better than zero.





A FINAL MESSAGE

Your body does not define your worth.

Fitness should increase your confidence, health, energy and quality of life — it should never become an obsession or a source of guilt.

The goal was never to become perfect.
The goal is to become a little healthier than yesterday.

STRONGER EVERY DAY

Thank you for reading The Beginner's Fitness Blueprint.